

- The music supervisor Amelia Hartley also added that the angry, but energetic punk songs also indicate the simmering emotion beneath Tommy's calm exterior. A key musical contribution is from Nick Cave and the Bad Seeds, who provide the sinister theme song, and contributed 14 songs in total over six seasons.

Consider theoretical approaches

Narratology – Todorov:

- Consider how *Peaky Blinders* fits into **Todorov's** five step narrative structure, and how it also plays with it. Think about the interesting reversal of protagonist and antagonist, and the way the audience are encouraged to empathise with the criminals.
- **The equilibrium:** the opening scenes establish Tommy as a man of great status. They also show the day-to-day running of the Shelby's gambling operation, but the **disruption** (the mistaken theft of the guns) has already occurred and further disruption (Campbell's campaign) is already beginning.
- As befits a long-form drama, almost every character has their own narrative arc, e.g. we see Arthur's equilibrium, more firmly disrupted by his ordeal with the police. Only a few of these are resolved in the first episode, and this encourages viewers to watch the entire series. To examine how each of these arcs manifests in season 1 and 2, look at the actor interviews in the BBC production notes: <https://bbc.in/3L49dUc>
- There are some **recognitions** hinted at in the focus episode, e.g. the Shelbys know Campbell's identity and reputation before he even arrives.
- **Enigma codes** often drive long-form drama by constantly introducing new characters and narrative twists – some of which are answered with others leading to further enigmas.

Genre – Steve Neale:

- Neale says that though genres may be seen as being limited by familiar **tropes**, they are also marked by **difference**, variation, and change.

- Gangster films and historical dramas have a recognisable array of conventions that produce audience pleasures. These include narrative ingredients like anti-heroes, scenes of suspense and violence, but also more aesthetic pleasures like spectacular locations and costumes.
- However, Neale would say they also need to display something original to set them apart from other examples. Evolution is essential to sustain a genre, and *Peaky Blinders* does this by offering greater depth and complexity to the typical 'tough guys'. It does this by rooting their violence in historical and socio-economic context (especially PTSD). When considering the set design and its location, it is not only industrial but also hellish – fire explodes or glimmers in almost every scene in this episode. This offers a distinctly different aesthetic to other period dramas like *Bridgerton*.

PART 2: STARTING POINTS – Representation

Consider how representations may invoke discourses and ideologies and position audiences (A Level only).

- Knight said that he is deliberately trying to tell stories about the 'secret history of England' that may be darker, more violent and subversive than the more sanitised view of British history portrayed in mainstream costume dramas. There are no glimpses of aristocracy, businessmen or factory owners, at least in season 1, the focus is entirely on working class people and one area.
- Knight's intentional '**mythologising**' of industrial communities, however criminal, has resulted in a fresh sense of civic pride in Birmingham. There are now *Peaky Blinders* tours, theme pubs, and a Rambert dance production in Birmingham.
- The representation of men as brutal and violent is complicated by the Shelby boys' experiences in the war. Knight described them as 'men who have forgotten about physical consequences.' Though apparently fearless, in reality, they are suffering from PTSD.